From Your Head to Their Hands: A Step-by-Step Plan for Getting Your Wife's Preferences to Her New Caregivers

Nine actions, in order, with a line for who does each and by when.

The goal: a short page about your wife that she has confirmed where she can, with her preferences kept apart from her clinicians' instructions, and the name of the person on the new team who will receive it.

More than one of you can take a part. Put a name and a day next to each action, and tick it when it's done.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Ask her to describe a good day. Write down what she says, in her words.			
2. Write down her usual morning and evening, in the order things happen.			
3. Write down what she likes to eat and drink, and when she usually eats.			
4. On a separate sheet, list any allergy or dietary instruction a clinician has given you, with who gave it and when. Keep it apart from her likes and dislikes.			
5. List the activities she enjoys and the people who matter to her.			
6. Write down how she likes to be spoken to, starting with the name she wants to be called.			
7. Ask her what helps when she's somewhere unfamiliar, and add what she says.			
8. Read the page back to her where possible. Change what she corrects, and mark anything she hasn't confirmed.			
9. Make a short version for the new team, with only what she's agreed to share, and write down who will receive it.			

You're done when

The page about her has been read back to her where possible, her preferences and her clinicians' instructions sit on separate lists, and you have the name of the person who will receive it. What the new team does with the page, and any decision about her care, isn't on this list, because it isn't the family's to do alone.

If the week gets away from you

- Don't fill a gap by guessing what she'd say. “Haven't asked her yet” is a finished line.

- If you can't tell whether something about food is her preference or a clinician's instruction, leave it off both lists and write it down as a question for the nurse.
- If her first day arrives and the page isn't finished, bring what you have, with the date on it.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your part. It doesn't certify that anything is clinically safe, authorize any treatment or any change to her diet, or stand in for the professionals who assess her.

Ready for the next step?

You've taken what was in your head and put it, step by step, where her new caregivers can read it. The care interview does the same for the rest of her situation: it goes through her care needs and the people who support her with you, area by area, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›